veiled under the ambit of farmers protests against the new farm laws had intensified their presence at five border points of the national capital: Singhu, Tikri, Ghazipur, Palwal and Shahjahanpur. The crowds were large and unruly. No COVID-19 protocol in sight. No consideration for their own or national safety. When asked about the fear of the virus by the news channel cameramen, they'd say, 'The new laws will kill us, COVID-19 might not.'[19]

Seventy-one years ago, on this day—26 January—India's Constitution came into effect, making us the world's largest democracy. Each Republic Day, we celebrate this remarkable achievement in democratic self-governance with an elaborate five-kilometre-long parade in the national capital displaying India's military prowess with tanks, weaponry and precision marching by the Armed Forces and the world's dignitaries joining our top leadership along Rajpath to view the spectacle. The parade begins near the Presidential Palace, passes through India Gate and winds up at the Red Fort.

This year, keeping in mind COVID-19-appropriate protocol, the parade was planned to be shorter, culminating at the National Stadium versus the Red Fort, with smaller marching contingents and fewer cultural performances. Only 25,000 spectators along the three-and-a-half kilometre stretch were to be permitted as opposed to over one and a half lakh every year.

Earlier in the week, the protesting farmers' unions under their umbrella body, Samyukta Kisan Morcha (SKM), had sought permission to hold a tractor march in the national capital, coinciding with the Republic Day parade. They assured the Delhi Police that they would take routes which would not interfere with the Republic Day parade and the tractor march would remain a peaceful affair. On 24 January, the Delhi Police gave them permission to hold this tractor march on 26 January, falling short of providing a time frame to complete the march. Farmers' unions interpreted this communication lapse as a march which would be allowed to go on in the national capital from anywhere between 24 to 72 hours beginning on 26 January. The Delhi Police put security arrangements in place by barricading the routes on which they wouldn't be permitted. For their rally, which had permission to mobilize only 5,000 tractors, over two lakh tractor-trolleys had planned to enter from the five border points and cover over a hundred kilometres.[20]